

Local Competitor Research Worksheet

A working document for studying how nearby competitors appear, position themselves, earn trust, and turn local visibility into customer action. The goal is to understand the market, not to copy it.

How to use this worksheet: Pick a small, meaningful competitor set. Research each business using the same searches, the same observations, and roughly the same time window. Record what you can verify. Separate what you observed from what you think it means.

1. Research setup

Field	Your notes
Business being researched	
Primary service/product	
Primary market/city	
Research date/time	
Search device/location context	
Main customer type	
Competitor set size	

2. Build a competitor set that makes sense

Do not choose competitors only because they appear first. Include businesses that compete for the same customer, the same service need, or the same local search intent.

Competitor	Why they compete	Type	Location/area
1.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
2.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
3.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
4.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
5.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
6.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
7.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	
8.		Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid	

3. Search the same way a real customer might

- [] Business name + city | Search observed: _____
- [] Primary service + city | Search observed: _____
- [] Primary service + near me | Search observed: _____
- [] Problem/need + city | Search observed: _____
- [] Alternative service wording + city | Search observed: _____
- [] Brand + service | Search observed: _____
- [] Service + neighborhood/area | Search observed: _____
- [] Emergency/urgent version if relevant | Search observed: _____

Record the actual search context. Local results can vary by location, device, query wording, and other factors. A single search position is an observation, not a permanent ranking claim.

4. Google Business Profile review

Area	What to inspect	Observed
Name	Does the name look like the real-world business name? Any obvious keyword stuffing or location additions?	
Category	Primary category; visible additional categories where available; does category fit the business?	
Hours	Regular hours, special hours, appointment-only signals, seasonal changes	
Location model	Storefront, service-area, or hybrid; is the public location consistent with the business model?	
Services	Which services are listed? Are descriptions useful? Is anything obviously missing?	
Photos	Quality, freshness, relevance, products/services represented, storefront/working environment	
Reviews	Review volume, recency, themes, owner responses, recurring complaints or praise	
Website link	Does it lead to the correct site and a useful landing page for the customer?	
Actions	Booking/order/contact actions or other category-specific links where available	

5. Competitor website and conversion experience

- [] First impression: can you tell what they do, where they serve, and who they help within a few seconds?
- [] Service pages: are the important services explained in plain language?
- [] Local relevance: are service areas or location pages clearly presented without awkward keyword stuffing?
- [] Proof: reviews, case studies, credentials, photos, guarantees, examples, or other trust elements?
- [] Conversion path: is it obvious what to do next?
- [] Contact friction: how many clicks or fields before a customer can make contact?

[] Mobile experience: does the site remain usable on a phone?

[] Technical experience: obvious slow pages, broken links, mixed content, security warnings, or inaccessible elements?

6. Positioning and offer analysis

Question	Competitor A	Competitor B	Competitor C
What do they lead with?			
Who do they seem to target?			
What do they promise?			
What proof do they use?			
What makes them different?			
What is unclear or missing?			

7. Reviews: look for patterns, not just stars

A star average is only part of the story. Read enough recent reviews to identify recurring customer language.

Pattern	Evidence / exact theme in your own words	Frequency	Opportunity or risk
What customers praise			
What customers complain about			
What customers mention most			
Questions customers repeatedly ask			
Words customers use for the service			

8. Local visibility outside Google

[] Major directories and industry-specific directories where customers actually look

[] Local chamber, association, trade group, or community listings

[] Relevant local news, sponsorships, events, organizations, or partner mentions

[] Consistent business name, phone, website, and address/service-area representation

[] Social profiles that are active enough to represent the business accurately

[] Third-party pages that contain outdated, duplicate, or incorrect information

Do not turn this into a giant citation-counting exercise. Ask a better question: Which third-party mentions actually help a customer find, verify, or understand this business?

9. Turn observations into findings

Findin g	Evidence	Why it matters	Possible response
1.			
2.			
3.			
4.			
5.			
6.			
7.			
8.			

10. Questions to answer before you make a recommendation

- ☐ What do the strongest local competitors make easy for customers?
- ☐ Where does our business provide a clearer or more useful experience?
- ☐ Which visibility problems are factual/technical and which are competitive?
- ☐ Which gaps can be fixed in the existing profile or website?
- ☐ Which improvements would require new content, new processes, or a different platform?
- ☐ What evidence would show that a change actually helped?
- ☐ Which observations are strong enough to act on, and which need more data?

Keep the conclusion grounded: the purpose of competitor research is to understand the field. It should help you see where the market is crowded, where customers are being served well, and where there may be room to do something more useful. It should not automatically become a recommendation to copy the top listing.

Source note

This worksheet uses Google's current Business Profile documentation for policy-sensitive fields such as eligibility, categories, service areas, profile information, and local ranking context. The comparative research framework itself is an original working method intended to separate observations from conclusions.

Core Google sources: <https://support.google.com/business/answer/3038177> | <https://support.google.com/business/answer/13763036> | <https://support.google.com/business/answer/9157481> | <https://support.google.com/business/answer/7091>